

IT SEEMS THAT EVERYONE CHASES THE PERFECT FRENCH FRY.

Our technique is to soak them in salted water and then steam them in the pressure cooker to hydrate the starches and gelatinize them before a final frying round. This produces perfectly cooked potatoes encased in a thin, crisp outer shell. A sprinkling of salt is all you really need to finish them off.

SERVES 4 AS A SIDE DISH

FRENCH FRIES

In a large bowl, combine the water and salt and stir until the salt is dissolved.

Peel the potatoes. Square off the top and bottom of each potato and then trim a small slice off the bottom of each one so that it lies flat on the cutting board. Cut the potato into $\frac{3}{8}$ -inch-thick (1 cm) planks. Lay each plank flat on the cutting board and cut lengthwise into $\frac{3}{8}$ -inch-wide (1 cm) batons. Put the potato batons in the bowl of salt water and let them soak for 2 to 3 hours.

Drain the potatoes and discard the water. Put the potatoes in a bowl that fits easily inside your pressure cooker. Put 2 inches (5 cm) of water in the cooker and set a small rack inside. Put the bowl on the rack and cook at high pressure for 5 minutes. Let the pressure dissipate naturally. Remove the lid of the pressure cooker and immediately remove the potatoes from the bowl and lay them out on a wire rack to cool to room temperature, about 30 minutes. (If you leave them to cool in the bowl they will stick to each other and to the bowl.) Refrigerate the potatoes, uncovered, for up to 6 hours, until you are ready to fry, or cover when completely cold and refrigerate for up to 24 hours.

Preheat the oven to 250°F (120°C).

Fill a large pot with 2 inches (5 cm) of oil and heat it to 400°F (205°C). Put about one-quarter of the potatoes in the oil and stir them with a metal spider skimmer. The temperature should drop to about 375°F (190°C). Cook the potatoes until they are a deep golden brown on the outside and cooked through, about 5 minutes. It's important to cook these potatoes all the way through or they will steam as they cool and lose their crisp texture. Transfer the fries to a wire rack and season generously with salt. Put the rack with the fries into the warm oven while frying the remaining batches. Serve hot.

6 $\frac{2}{3}$ cups / 1,500 grams
water

2 $\frac{1}{2}$ tablespoons / 45 grams
fine sea salt, plus more for
seasoning the fries

6 large russet potatoes

Rice bran oil or peanut oil,
for frying

